

make even the most seasoned of Mac users stare at the screen dumbfounded. The first problem is that there is little consistency. The Finder, Dashboard, Mail, iTunes, iPhoto, GarageBand and TextEdit all sport a different sort of user interface. There are at least seven different kinds of user interfaces in a default installation of Mac OS X. The pro applications have an entirely different user interface for them. Though a casual Mac user would hardly even notice these sometimes subtle differences between the user interfaces of various applications, it is something that has the purists up in arms. Apple often shows blatant disregard for the set of Macintosh Human Interface Guidelines that they advise third-party developers to follow.

One example of this inconsistency is the zoom button. Unlike its maximise counterpart in Windows, the zoom button is supposed to change the size of the window to just contain the contents within, not the whole window. So if you open a Web page in Safari and hit the zoom button, Safari will not fill up the whole screen. It will be enlarged or shrunk to the exact size it needs to be to contain the Web page. But Mail will just maximise on hitting the zoom button. And iTunes actually shrinks to mini mode if you click on zoom. This is one of the biggest problems faced by new users of Mac OS X.

In Windows, you can drag any side or corner of a window in either direction to enlarge or shrink the windows. In Mac OS X, you can only use one handle at the lower right corner of all windows. This poses two problems. The first is that if there is no space on the right or below the window, you have to first drag it away from the edge and then enlarge it. The second is that you can never increase just one of the dimensions unless you either have precise control over the movement of the mouse or you like to do things really slowly. This is a little nag that shows Apple's absolutely stubborn attitude towards innovations made by Microsoft. While Microsoft happily embraces each and every innovative feature introduced by Apple, Apple has a hard time accepting that an idea occurred to the engineers at Microsoft that Apple could not come up with. This is the sole reason Apple had been supporting single button mice for a long time, even though it was pretty clear